FAZE: Draft Database Product Document

CS 514 Database Theory and Implementation, Fall 2026, Phase 1

Bryan Djenabia, Alvin Hoang, nickayvy

19 October 2026

1. Overview

FAZE helps a gamer find a group of real people to play with. A person saves the games they play, their platform, their region and their weekly free time. FAZE then ranks the open groups for that person with one SQL query, and lets them join a group and chat with its members.

The problem. Finding people to play with is still guesswork: Reddit threads, a huge “looking for group” channel on Discord, or a game’s random matchmaking. None of these look at the three things that decide whether a group sticks together: playing the same game, being in the same region, and being free at the same times. Those are facts about people, games and schedules, which is exactly what a relational database answers well.

The company. For this course we present FAZE as a small software company, FAZE Labs. Its mission is to help every player find a group they actually stick with.

Person	Role
Bryan Djenabia	Project lead, database design, the match query
Alvin Hoang	Profiles, time zones and the group messages API
nickayvy	Groups API, the website, demo data, screenshots

Input and output. The input is a person’s profile (games, region, platform, weekly availability). The output is a ranked list of groups, each with a score out of 100 and the reasons for it, plus the group pages and chat.

How we measure success. (1) The ranking is exactly what the scoring rule says, checked by automated tests. (2) Joining stays correct when many people press Join at once. (3) The main queries stay fast on a large data set, measured with `EXPLAIN ANALYZE`.

2. Database design

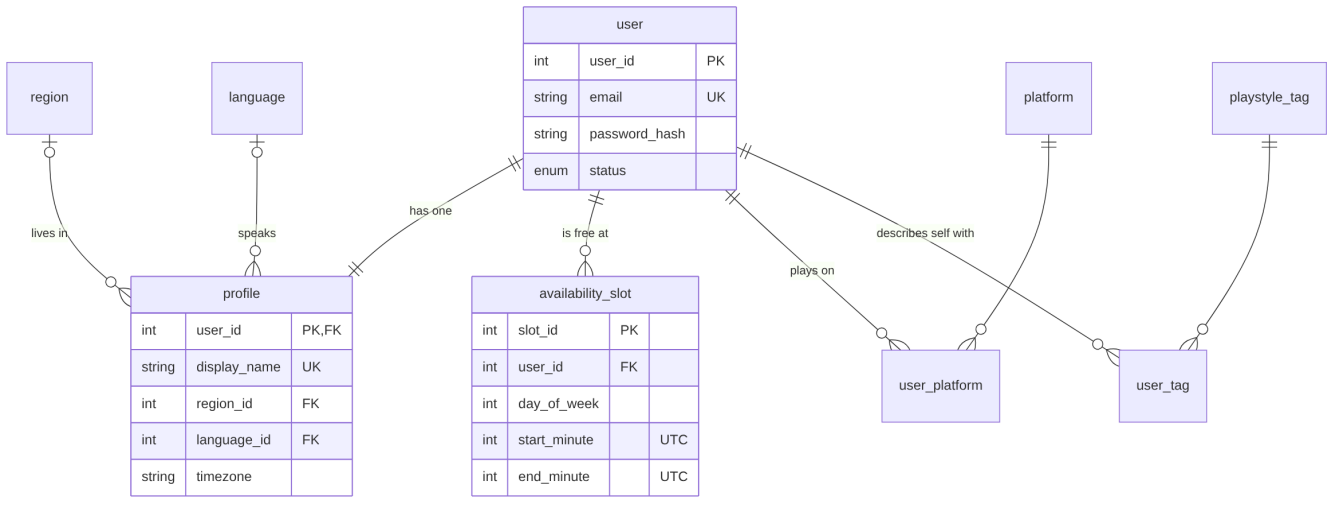
2.1 The schema at a glance

Item	Count
Application tables	29
Foreign keys	41, each with a deliberately chosen `ON DELETE` rule
`CHECK` constraints	21
Views	6
Stored procedures	6
Triggers	7
Migrations	12, numbered, each with a tested rollback

The database is MySQL 8 (InnoDB, `utf8mb4`). All SQL is written by hand with bound parameters; there is no ORM.

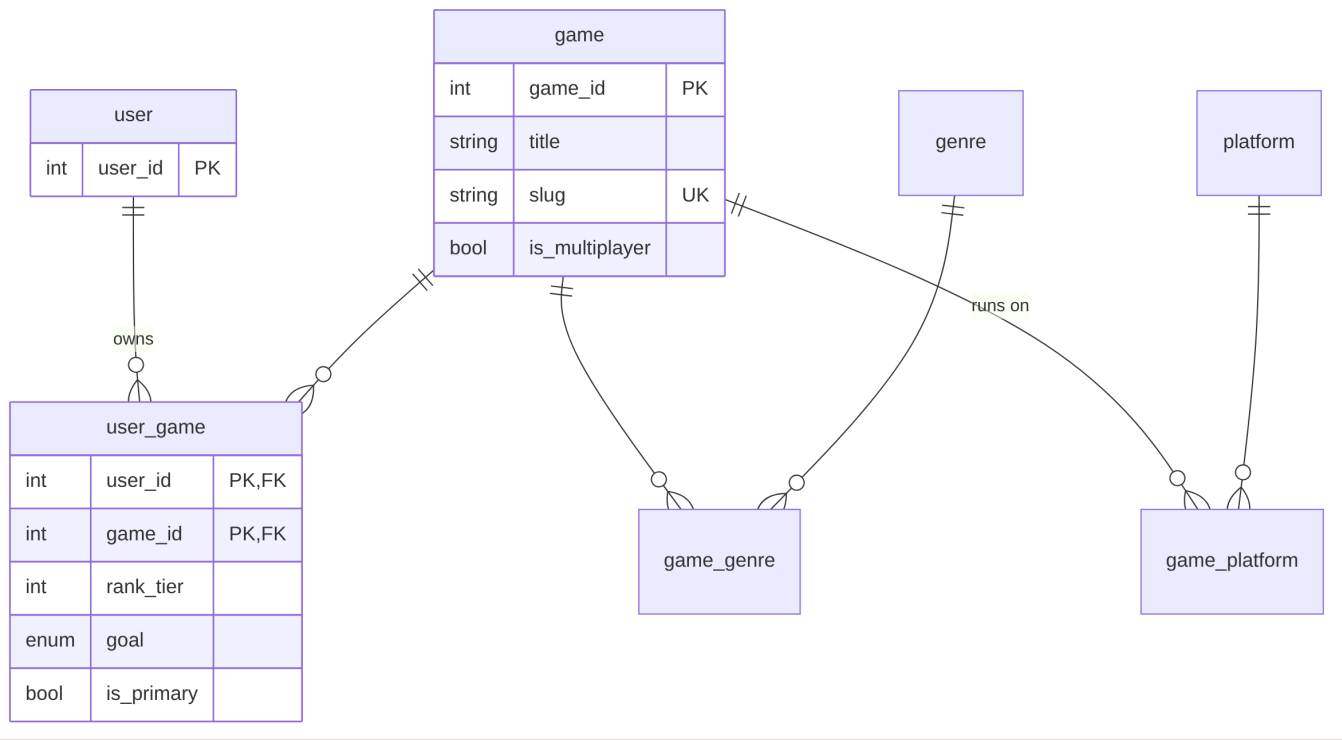
2.2 ER diagram

The diagram is split into three pictures so the text stays readable. Each one has its own page. The first shows people: users, profiles, weekly availability, platforms and play styles.



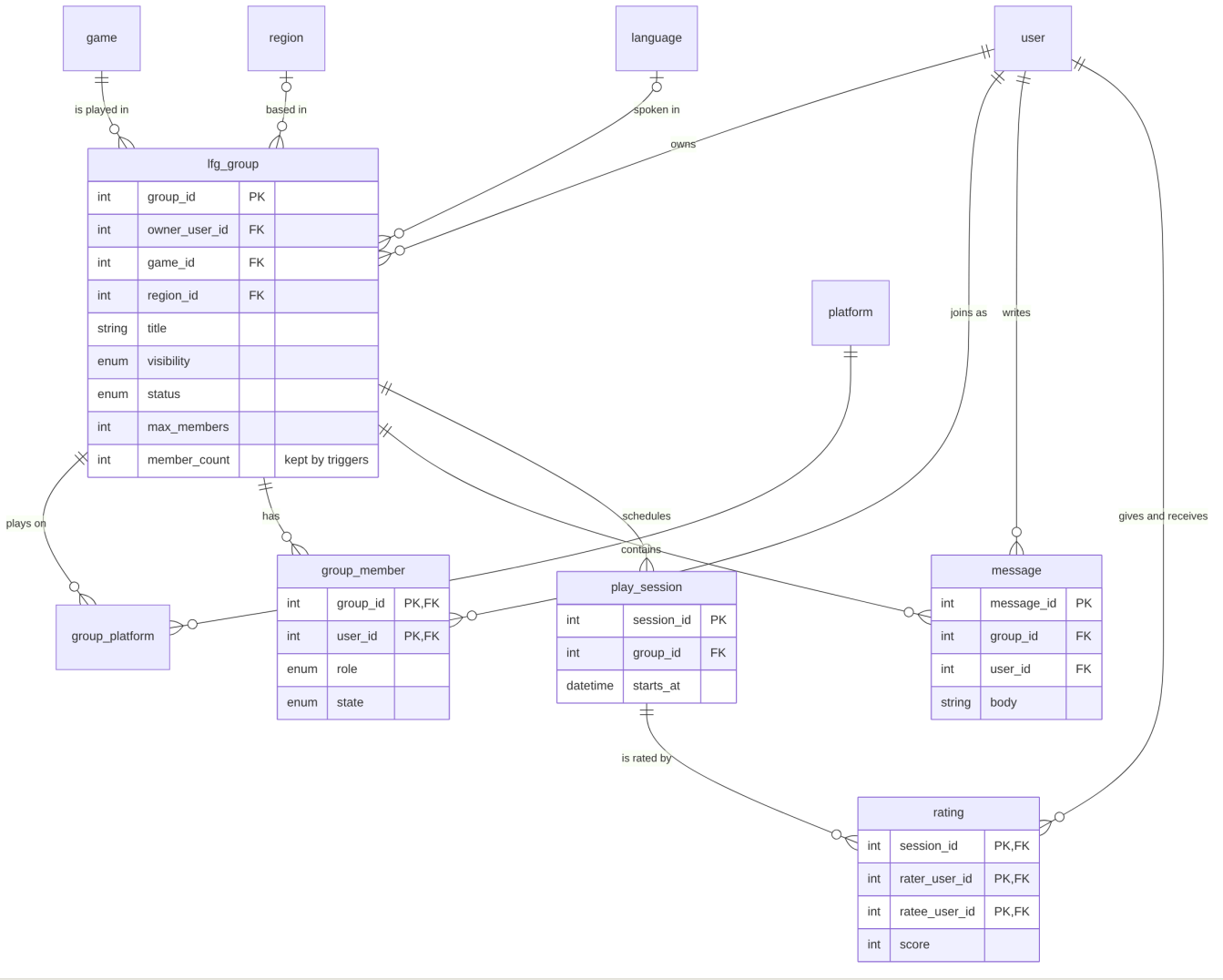
ER diagram, part 1: people, profiles and availability

The second shows games: the games people own, and each game’s genres and platforms.



ER diagram, part 2: games, genres and platforms

The third shows groups: the group itself, its members, messages, sessions and ratings.



ER diagram, part 3: groups, members, messages and sessions

2.3 Normalisation

We started from one “everything in a spreadsheet” table and took it step by step to 1NF (no lists inside a cell), 2NF (no column depends on only part of a key) and 3NF (no column depends on another non-key column). The full walk-through is in `docs/normalization.md`. Every table is in BCNF except one deliberate exception.

The one deliberate denormalisation. `lfg_group.member_count` repeats a number the database could count. The browse and match queries read it for every group, so counting each time would be slow. Only triggers may change it, and the view `v_member_count_reconciliation` shows any difference between the stored count and the real count. That difference was 0 for all 5,000 groups in our performance data set, and the demo data script checks it every time it runs.

2.4 Storing availability

Weekly free time is stored as UTC minutes since midnight (for example Monday 18:00 to 20:00 UTC is day 1, minutes 1080 to 1200). People enter times in their own time zone and the server converts them to UTC before saving, splitting a slot that runs past midnight into two days. Because of this, the question “do two people overlap?” is plain integer arithmetic in SQL.

3. Implementation

3.1 Architecture

Layer	Technology	Notes
Database	MySQL 8	Schema changes only through migration files
Server	Node 20, Express, TypeScript	Routes, services, repositories; SQL only in repositories
Website	React, Vite, Tailwind	Login, profile, groups, matches, group page, chat
Shared types	zod schemas	The server and website check the same shapes
Checks	GitHub Actions	Lint, type check, build, and tests on a real MySQL

3.2 Real data

The game catalog comes from a public Steam dataset. It is loaded into a staging table first, then cleaned, and every rejected row is logged with a reason.

Step	Rows
Staged	140,082 apps
Loaded as games	**118,001**
Rejected and logged	22,081 (17,891 demos, 2,282 duplicates, 1,908 non-Latin titles)
Flagged multiplayer	22,821
Genre links	326,743 across 63 genres

Running the import again gives the same counts.

3.3 Key SQL 1: a trigger keeps the stored count right

```
CREATE TRIGGER trg_group_member_ai
AFTER INSERT ON group_member
FOR EACH ROW
BEGIN
  IF NEW.state = 'active' THEN
    UPDATE lfg_group SET member_count = member_count + 1
     WHERE group_id = NEW.group_id;
    UPDATE lfg_group SET status = 'full'
     WHERE group_id = NEW.group_id AND status = 'recruiting'
       AND member_count >= max_members;
  END IF;
END;
```

3.4 Key SQL 2: joining a group safely (the transaction)

`sp_join_group` starts a transaction and locks the group's row before it checks for a free seat, so two people can never both take the last one.

```
START TRANSACTION;
SELECT max_members, member_count, visibility
  INTO v_max_members, v_member_count, v_visibility
  FROM lfg_group WHERE group_id = p_group_id
  FOR UPDATE;                          -- the row lock
-- refuse with FULL, ALREADY_MEMBER or a requirement code
INSERT INTO group_member (group_id, user_id, role, state)
VALUES (p_group_id, p_user_id, 'member', 'active')
ON DUPLICATE KEY UPDATE role = 'member', state = 'active', left_at = NULL;
SET p_result = 'JOINED';
COMMIT;
```

Proof. Eight people ran the procedure at the same moment for one free seat, three times. Every time exactly one got `JOINED` and seven got `FULL`. Before the count trigger existed, the same test let all eight in, which shows why the lock and the trigger are both needed.

3.5 Key SQL 3: the match score

For each open group the score is **50** (same game) **+ 20** (same region) **+ up to 30** (shared weekly free time). A group has no schedule of its own, so we use the average number of weekly hours the person shares with each member; 10 hours or more earns the full 30 points.

```
  :gameWeight * same_game
+ :regionWeight * same_region
+ LEAST(:availabilityWeight,
        :availabilityWeight * overlap_hours / :fullHours) AS score
```

Groups that are full, private or already joined are left out. The server only passes in the user id and returns the rows. Four automated tests check the exact scores and their order (80, 76, 50 and 20 in the test world).

3.6 API

The website talks to 33 JSON routes, including `POST /api/auth/login`, `PUT /api/profile`, `GET /api/groups`, `POST /api/groups/:id/join`, `GET /api/matches` and `GET /api/groups/:id/messages`. Every route is listed in `docs/api.md`.

4. Course concepts applied

Concept	Where it appears in FAZE
ER modelling	Two-part ER diagram (section 2.2)
Keys and constraints	Primary keys, 41 foreign keys with `ON DELETE` rules, 21 `CHECK` constraints
Normalisation (1NF to BCNF)	Walk-through in `docs/normalization.md`; one defended exception
Joins and aggregation	The match query joins profiles, games, members and availability
Views	`v_group_card`, `v_member_count_reconciliation` and four more
Stored procedures	Create, join and leave a group; set the primary game
Triggers	Keep `member_count` correct; audit changes; rating checks
Transactions and locking	`SELECT ... FOR UPDATE` in `sp_join_group`; the 8-people race test
Indexing and query plans	Composite, availability and `FULLTEXT` indexes, measured with `EXPLAIN ANALYZE`
ETL and data cleaning	Steam import with a staging table and a reject log
Security	argon2id password hashes, bound parameters, members-only access

5. Performance (compared with a baseline)

We filled a separate test database with **20,000 users, 5,000 groups and all 118,001 games**, then measured the three queries that matter with `EXPLAIN ANALYZE`, without and with the index.

Query	Baseline (no index)	With the index
Browse groups for a game and region	5.47 ms, full scan	**0.10 ms**
The match query (median of 5 runs)	295 ms	**164 ms**
Game search by title	81.6 ms, full scan	**0.21 ms**

Game search became about 390 times faster with a `FULLTEXT` index. The full query plans are in `docs/performance.md`.

6. Security and testing

- Passwords are hashed with argon2id; the hash is never logged or returned.
- Every SQL value is a bound parameter, and only repository files contain SQL.
- Protected routes need a signed-in user. Group messages are members only: a non-member, or someone who has left, is refused on both reading and posting.
- **78 automated tests** run on every pull request against a real MySQL database: sign-in, profiles, lookups, the match query, groups (including the 8-people race) and messages.

7. User guide

7.1 Run FAZE on your computer

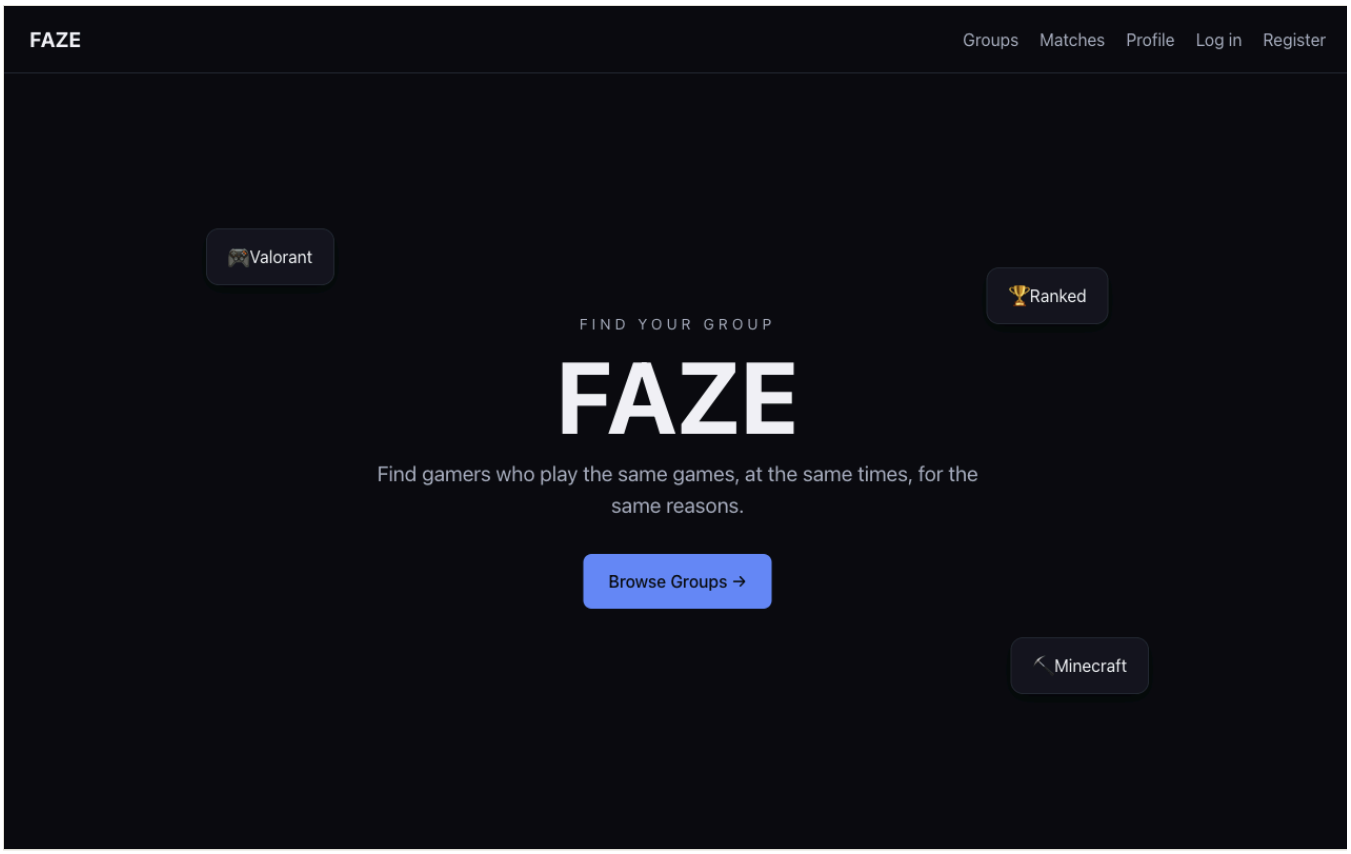
You need Node 20 or newer and either Docker or MySQL 8.

```
git clone https://github.com/BryanD17/FAZE.git
cd FAZE
npm install
docker compose up -d      # starts MySQL
cp .env.example .env      # then replace the two "replace-me" secrets
npm run db:migrate        # creates the tables
npm run etl:all           # loads the game list (a few minutes, once)
npm run db:seed           # 40 demo users, 15 groups, 200 messages
npm run dev               # website at http://localhost:5173
```

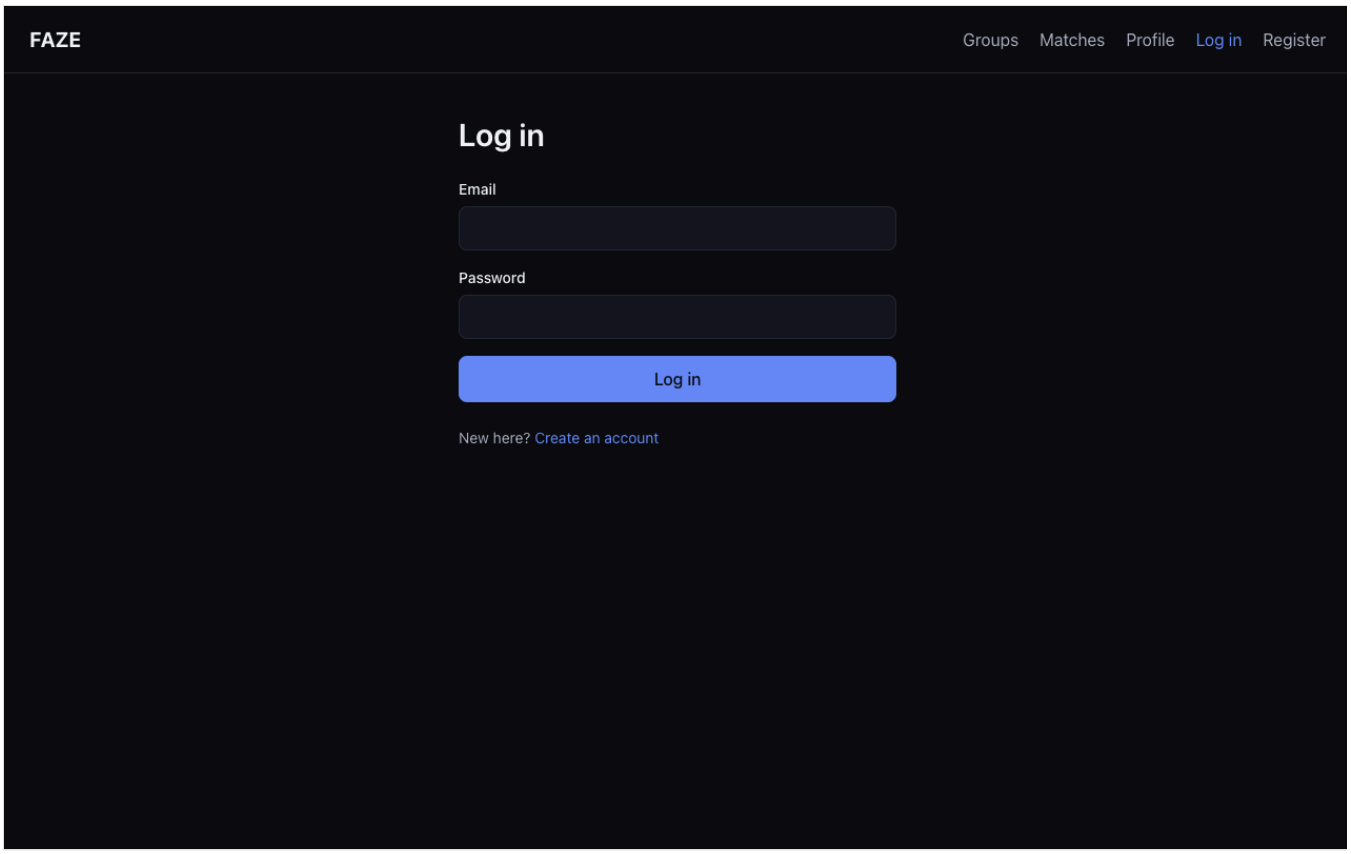
Every demo login is `<first name>@demo.faze` with the password `DemoPass123`. The main demo user is `maya@demo.faze`. Run `npm run db:seed` again at any time to reset the demo.

7.2 Using FAZE

Step 1. Register or log in. Open the website and create an account, or log in as a demo user.

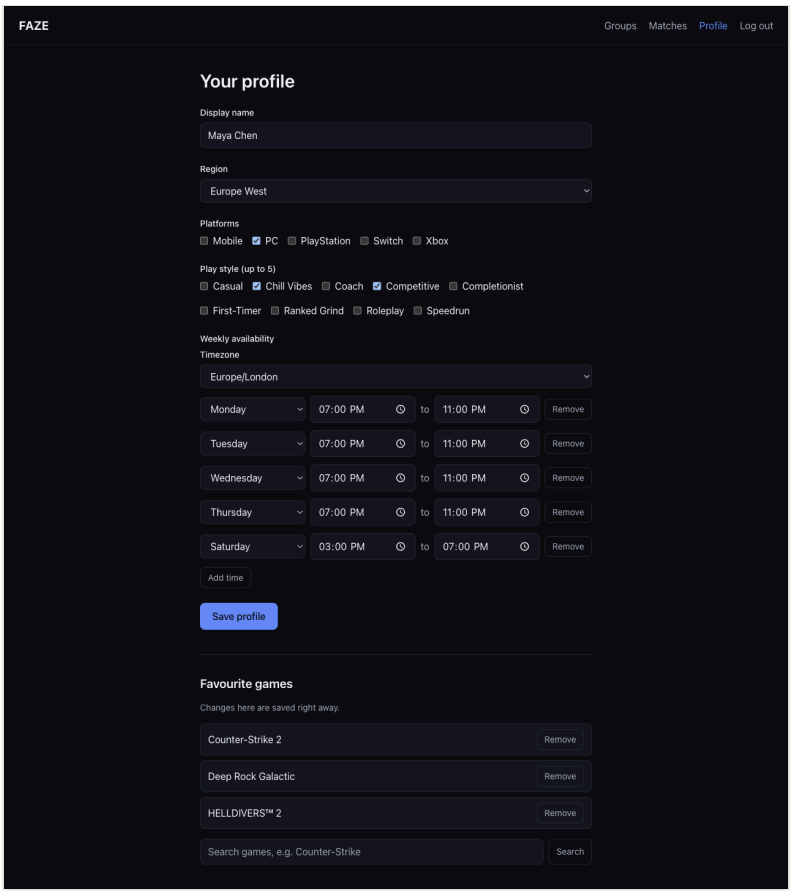

FAZE
Groups
Matches
Profile
Log in
Register
Valorant
Ranked
FIND YOUR GROUP
FAZE
Find gamers who play the same games, at the same times, for the same reasons.
Browse Groups →
Minecraft

Home page



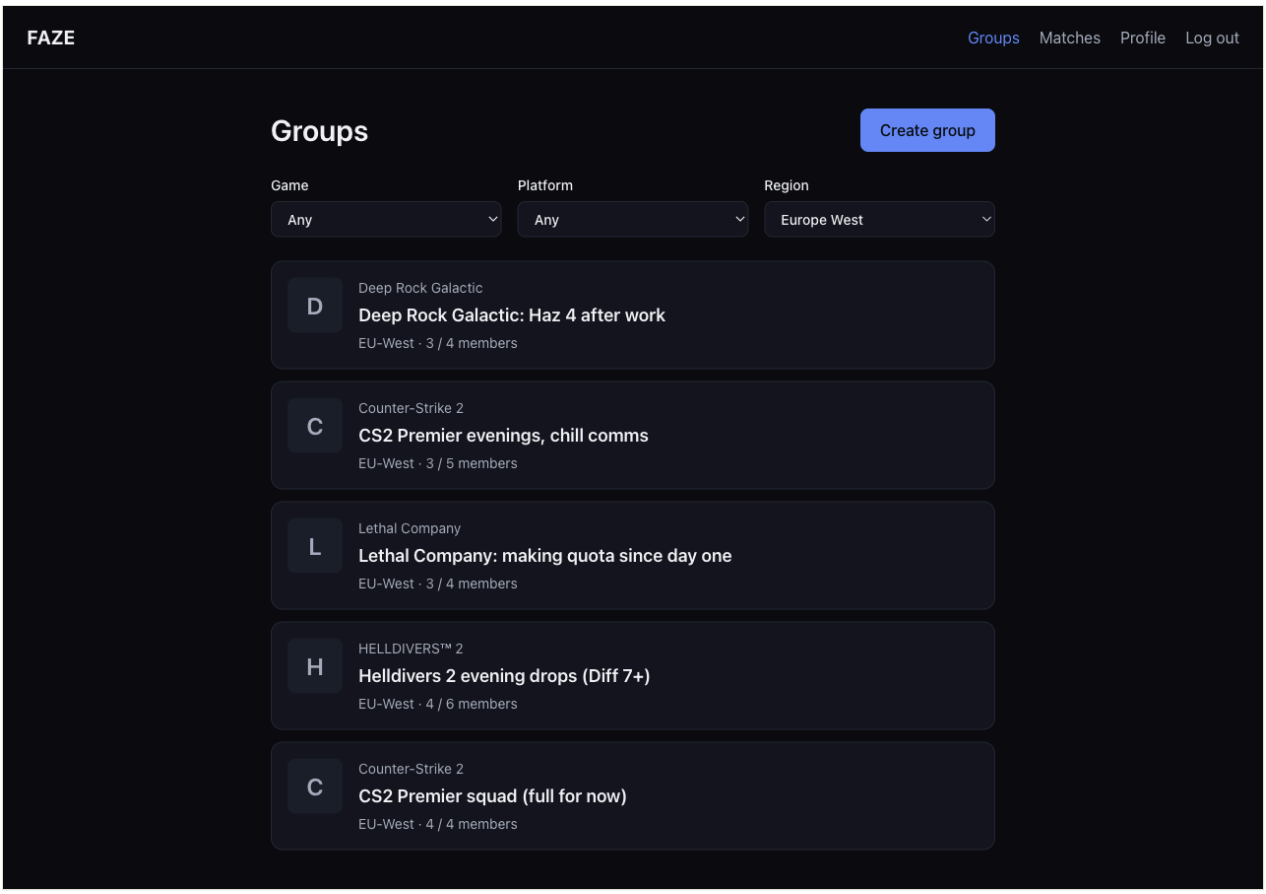
Log in

Step 2. Fill in your profile. Choose your region and platform, your play styles, your favourite games and the times you are free each week, in your own time zone. Press **Save profile**.



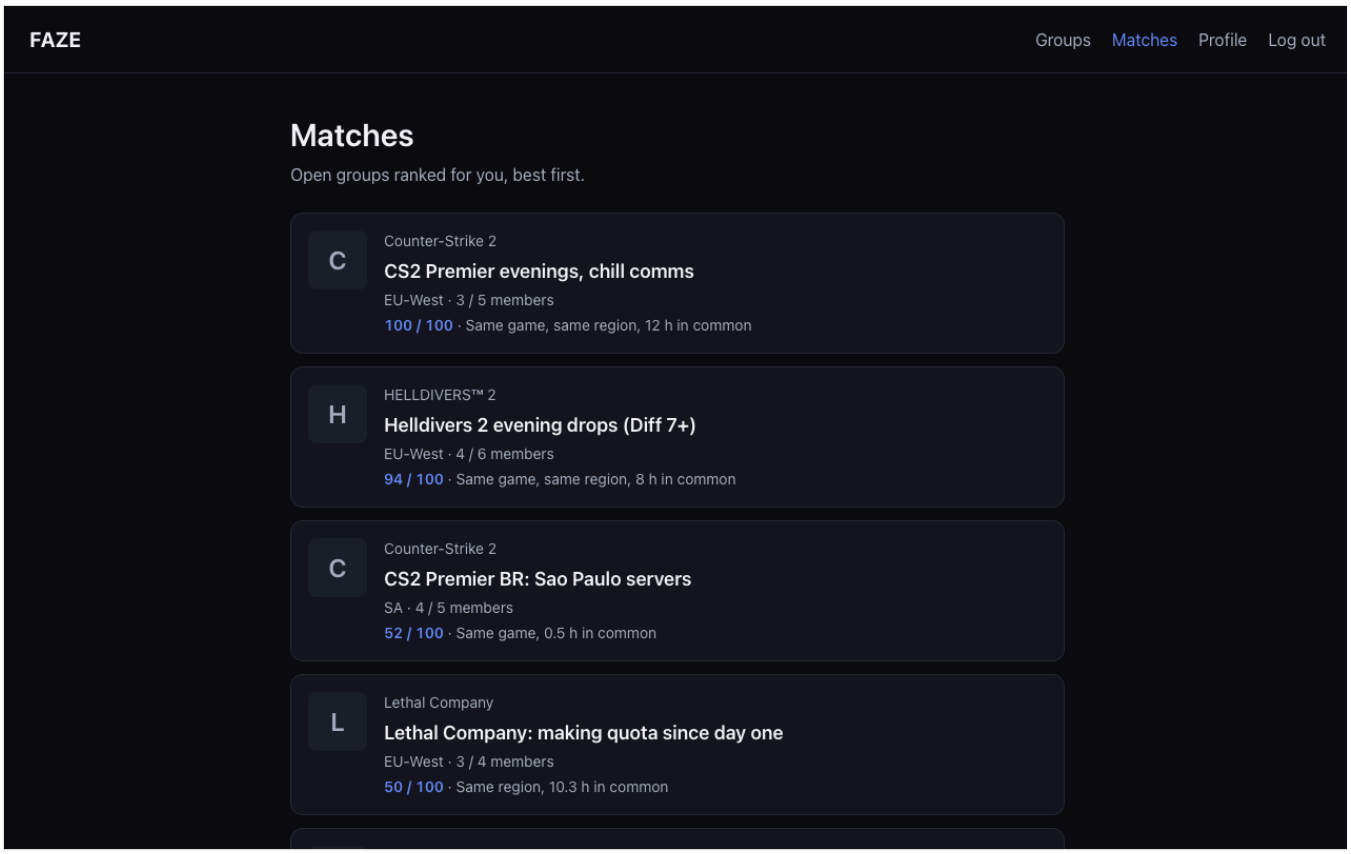
Profile page

Step 3. Browse groups. The Groups page lists every group. Filter by game or region. A full group shows its count (for example 4 / 4) and cannot be joined.



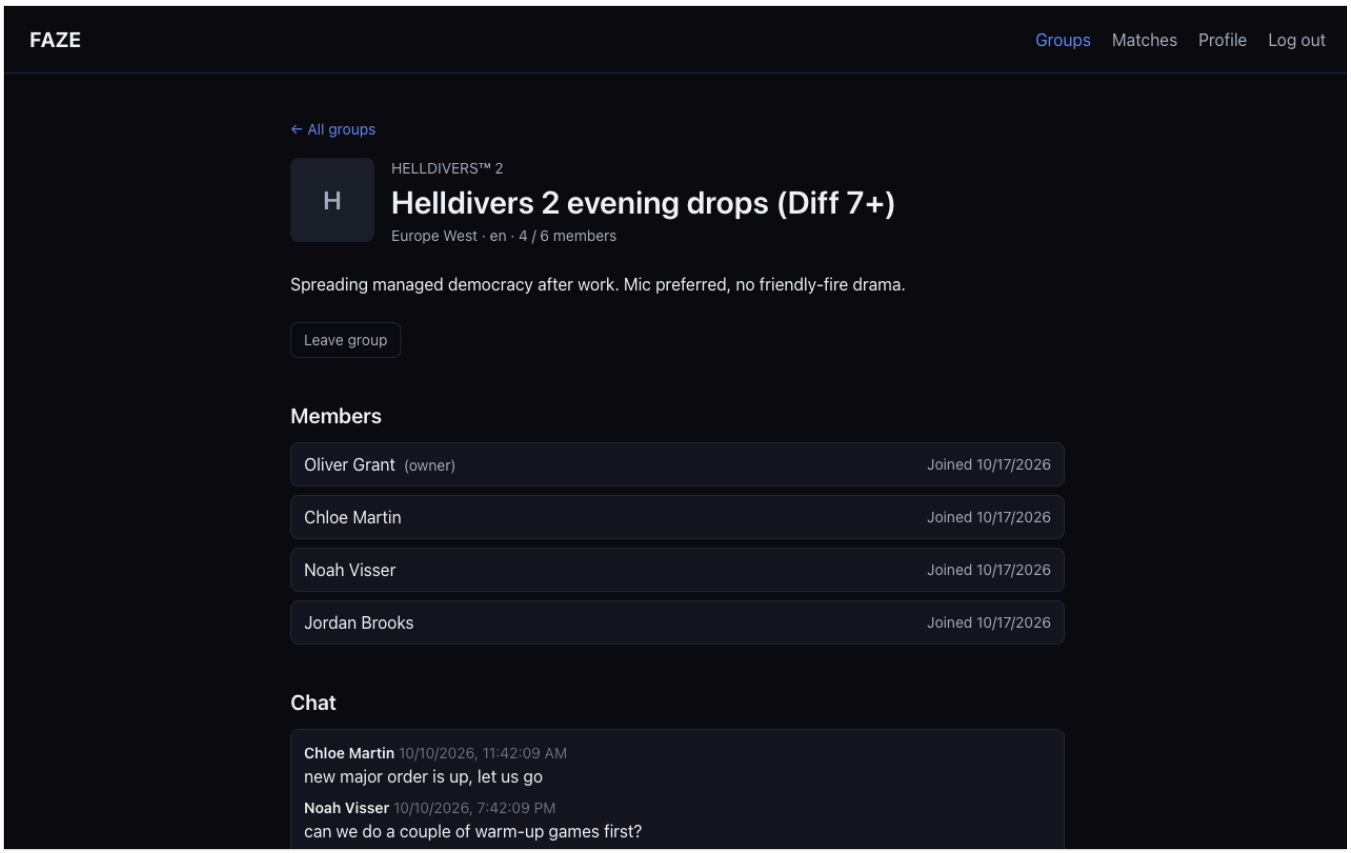
Groups page

Step 4. See your matches. The Matches page ranks open groups for you. Each card shows the score out of 100 and why: same game, same region and shared hours.

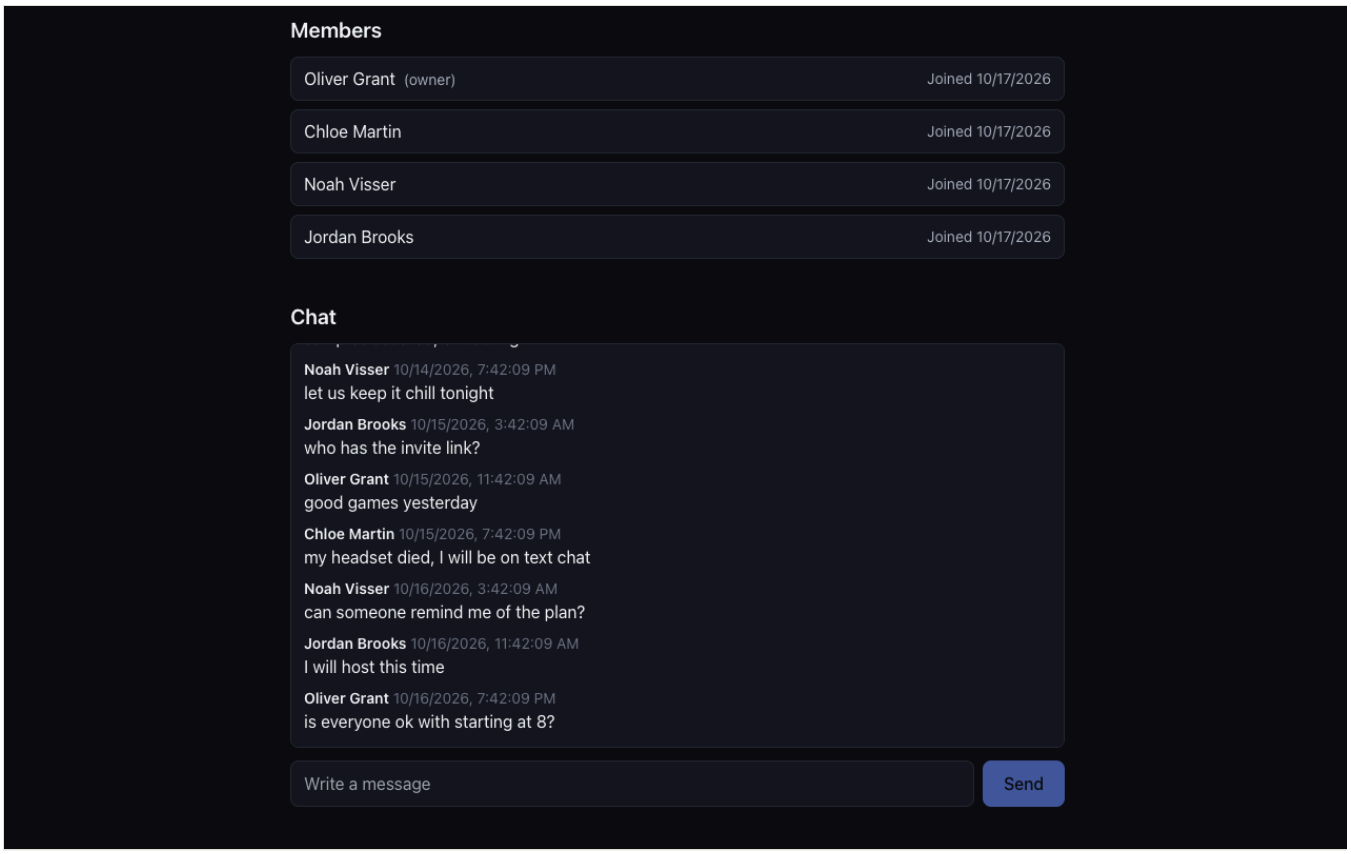


Matches page

Step 5. Join a group and chat. Open a group to see its members. Press **Join group** and you appear in the member list. Use the chat box to send a message; other members see it within a few seconds. Press **Leave** to leave.


FAZE
Groups
Matches
Profile
Log out
← All groups
H
HELLDIVERS™ 2
Helldivers 2 evening drops (Diff 7+)
Europe West · en · 4 / 6 members
Spreading managed democracy after work. Mic preferred, no friendly-fire drama.
Leave group
Members
Oliver Grant (owner)
Joined 10/17/2026
Chloe Martin
Joined 10/17/2026
Noah Visser
Joined 10/17/2026
Jordan Brooks
Joined 10/17/2026
Chat
Chloe Martin 10/10/2026, 11:42:09 AM
new major order is up, let us go
Noah Visser 10/10/2026, 7:42:09 PM
can we do a couple of warm-up games first?

Group page



Group chat

8. Who did what

Bryan Djenabia. Set up the project, the automatic checks and the review process. Designed the database (29 tables, the migration runner, 6 views, 6 stored procedures and 7 triggers), loaded the 118,001 games, built sign-in, wrote the match query, the ER diagram, the normalisation write-up and the performance evidence, and reviewed and merged the team's work.

Alvin Hoang. Built the profile API, including the conversion of weekly free time from the person's time zone to UTC, the lookup lists for the drop-down menus, and the members-only group messages API, each with automated tests.

nickayvy. Built the groups API (create, list, view, join and leave), the whole website including the live chat box, the demo data script and the screenshots.

9. Limitations and next steps

- Accounts are active as soon as they register; email sending is not built.
- Game cover art is not loaded; the website shows a placeholder.

- For Phase 2: key data-integrity tests, a short security check, and one clear guide to running the full demo.
- Optional if time allows: scheduling a group session and rating it afterwards.
- Beyond the class: Discord sign-in, a mobile app, and paid tools for gaming clubs and esports teams.